

ECONOMIC INTELLIGENCE SERIES

U.S. Metro Economic Health Report

50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas

Percentile-Based Composite Scoring · 8 Metrics · BLS & FRED Data
85% Employment / 15% Housing · April 2026

TOP PERFORMERS

#1	A+	Kansas City	74.4
#2	A+	Raleigh	72.8
#3	A+	Las Vegas	68.8
#4	A+	Hartford	68.8
#5	A	Salt Lake City	64.1
#6	A	Austin	64.0
#7	A	Birmingham	63.7

MARKETS UNDER PRESSURE

#50	D	Portland	23.9
#49	C-	Washington DC	26.4
#48	C-	Orlando	29.6
#47	C-	Baltimore	30.6
#46	C-	Richmond	31.4
#45	C	Jacksonville	32.3
#44	C	Detroit	32.9

GRADE DISTRIBUTION

A+ / A / A-	10 cities
B+ / B / B-	23 cities
C+ / C / C-	16 cities
D	1 cities

Data sources: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) · Federal Reserve Economic Data (FRED)
Unemployment, LFP, Earnings, Employment, Weekly Hours sourced from BLS LAUS / SAE.
Building Permits from Census Bureau via FRED. Days on Market from Realtor.com / FRED.

Scoring methodology: percentile ranking across all 50 metros.
Full methodology: SCORING_README.md
Pipeline runs weekly via GitHub Actions.

Full Rankings

All 50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas · Sorted by composite score · April 2026

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	LFP	DOM
1	Kansas City Kansas City	A+	74.4	3.5%	+7.0%	+1.4%	N/A	45 days
2	Raleigh Raleigh-Cary	A+	72.8	3.0%	+4.0%	+1.7%	N/A	46 days
3	Las Vegas Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas	A+	68.8	5.2%	+6.7%	+1.7%	N/A	52 days
4	Hartford Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford	A+	68.8	2.7%	+0.1%	+1.9%	N/A	39 days
5	Salt Lake City Salt Lake City-Murray	A	64.1	3.4%	+4.0%	+0.7%	N/A	45 days
6	Austin Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos	A	64.0	3.2%	+5.8%	+1.4%	N/A	53 days
7	Birmingham Birmingham	A	63.7	2.2%	-0.5%	+0.5%	N/A	56 days
8	Dallas Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington	A-	62.9	3.6%	+4.4%	+1.0%	N/A	48 days
9	Nashville Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin	A-	61.8	3.0%	+2.3%	+0.4%	N/A	53 days
10	Atlanta Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell	A-	59.5	3.3%	+6.5%	+0.1%	N/A	51 days
11	Pittsburgh Pittsburgh	B+	57.8	3.6%	+7.0%	+0.3%	N/A	65 days
12	Los Angeles Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim	B+	55.8	4.8%	+5.4%	+1.8%	N/A	45 days
13	Denver Denver-Aurora-Centennial	B	54.8	3.6%	+4.7%	-0.1%	N/A	38 days
14	Phoenix Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler	B	54.4	3.5%	+4.9%	-0.3%	N/A	54 days
15	Cincinnati Cincinnati	B	53.6	3.6%	+0.6%	+0.3%	N/A	45 days
16	Houston Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands	B	53.5	4.2%	+4.1%	+0.7%	N/A	50 days
17	Memphis Memphis	B	53.5	4.0%	+6.1%	-0.3%	N/A	62 days
18	Fresno Fresno	B	53.5	8.2%	+8.4%	+1.9%	N/A	51 days
19	San Jose San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara	B	51.4	4.0%	+0.7%	+1.7%	N/A	24 days
20	San Francisco San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont	B	50.5	4.1%	+5.5%	N/A	N/A	29 days
21	Charlotte Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia	B	50.2	3.6%	-1.3%	+0.8%	N/A	49 days
22	Columbus Columbus	B	50.1	3.6%	+3.0%	+0.3%	N/A	41 days
23	Miami Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach	B-	49.7	3.5%	+8.4%	-0.7%	N/A	74 days
24	New York New York-Newark-Jersey City	B-	49.6	4.5%	+5.5%	+0.1%	N/A	51 days

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	LFP	DOM
25	Cleveland Cleveland	B-	49.3	3.4%	-0.8%	+0.6%	N/A	55 days
26	San Diego San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad	B-	48.9	4.4%	+4.6%	+0.7%	N/A	38 days
27	Providence Providence-Warwick	B-	48.7	4.3%	+2.8%	+0.6%	N/A	48 days
28	Philadelphia Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington	B-	47.8	4.0%	+1.6%	+0.3%	N/A	43 days
29	Louisville Louisville-Jefferson County	B-	47.4	3.1%	+2.4%	-0.2%	N/A	45 days
30	Boston Boston-Cambridge-Newton	B-	47.1	3.9%	+3.4%	+0.7%	N/A	30 days
31	Seattle Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue	B-	45.8	5.0%	+9.0%	-0.1%	N/A	34 days
32	Riverside Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario	B-	44.5	5.1%	+6.7%	+0.9%	N/A	54 days
33	Sacramento Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom	B-	44.1	4.8%	+3.0%	+1.0%	N/A	39 days
34	San Antonio San Antonio-New Braunfels	C+	43.9	3.7%	+3.4%	+0.4%	N/A	61 days
35	Tampa Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater	C+	43.6	4.6%	+8.8%	-0.2%	N/A	66 days
36	Oklahoma City Oklahoma City	C+	43.6	3.6%	+5.4%	-0.5%	N/A	55 days
37	Indianapolis Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood	C+	42.4	2.5%	+4.0%	-0.7%	N/A	51 days
38	Grand Rapids Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood	C+	41.9	4.0%	+3.9%	-0.4%	N/A	44 days
39	St. Louis St. Louis	C+	38.9	3.5%	+1.4%	+0.2%	N/A	46 days
40	Virginia Beach Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk	C+	38.3	3.6%	+10.1%	-0.4%	N/A	36 days
41	Minneapolis Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington	C	36.5	4.0%	+1.5%	-0.1%	N/A	36 days
42	Milwaukee Milwaukee-Waukesha	C	36.2	3.1%	+3.5%	-0.8%	N/A	33 days
43	Chicago Chicago-Naperville-Elgin	C	34.8	4.5%	+4.0%	+0.3%	N/A	35 days
44	Detroit Detroit-Warren-Dearborn	C	32.9	N/A	+1.6%	-0.2%	N/A	45 days
45	Jacksonville Jacksonville	C	32.3	4.6%	+6.4%	-0.5%	N/A	58 days
46	Richmond Richmond	C-	31.4	3.3%	+5.4%	-0.4%	N/A	39 days
47	Baltimore Baltimore-Columbia-Towson	C-	30.6	3.6%	+3.0%	-1.5%	N/A	37 days
48	Orlando Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford	C-	29.6	4.4%	+1.4%	+0.5%	N/A	67 days
49	Washington DC Washington-Arlington-Alexandria	C-	26.4	3.8%	+1.9%	-3.1%	N/A	30 days
50	Portland Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro	D	23.9	4.9%	+5.0%	-1.8%	N/A	49 days

Kansas City

Kansas City

A+

EXCELLENT

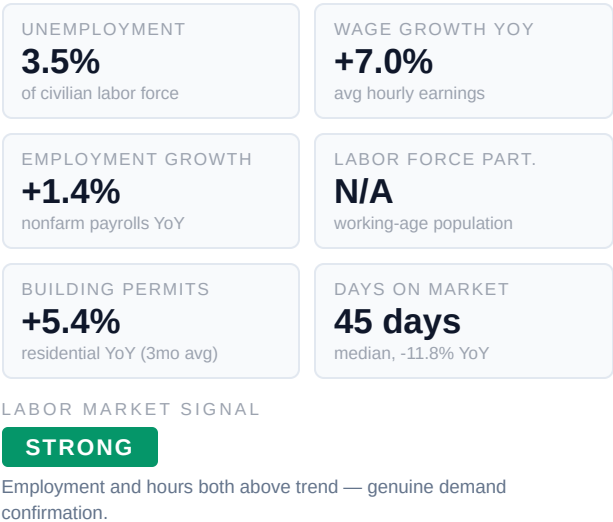
74.4th percentile

Rank 1 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Kansas City earns an A+ grade, driven by its exceptional economic performance, with rapid job creation and a growing workforce. The city's labor market is characterized by nonfarm employment growth of +1.39% year-over-year, ranking in the 96th percentile, and labor force growth of +2.10% year-over-year. Wages are rising fast, with hourly earnings increasing by +6.97% year-over-year, indicating a competitive labor market.

The city's below-average cost of living, with a composite score of 1.45, is a significant advantage. However, the housing market is experiencing a surge in demand, with homes selling in an average of 45 days on market, ranked in the 4th percentile. This fast-moving market poses a relocation challenge for new hires, who face intense competition for housing. Despite above-average building permit growth of +5.41% year-over-year, demand outpaces housing supply, eroding the affordability advantage.

Kansas City's thriving labor market makes it an attractive location for expansion, with rapid job creation and a growing workforce. However, the fast-moving housing market poses a significant risk, as relocating employees may struggle to secure affordable housing, potentially impacting talent attraction and retention.

Raleigh

Raleigh-Cary

A+

EXCELLENT

72.8th percentile

Rank 2 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.0%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+4.0%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+1.7%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

N/A

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+38.8%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

46 days

median, +4.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Raleigh earns an A+ overall grade, driven by its exceptionally tight labor market with a 3.00% unemployment rate and 1.70% year-over-year nonfarm employment growth. The city's highly affordable cost of living, with a composite index score of 1.43, indicates a strong cost advantage. Raleigh ranks in the 98th percentile for professional workforce concentration, making it attractive for knowledge-economy businesses and headquarters.

The labor force is growing slowly, at 0.53% year-over-year, which will constrain hiring capacity and exacerbate the tight labor market. The housing market is stabilizing, with days on market increasing by 4.5% year-over-year to an average of 46 days, a sign of healthy normalization given the strong employment growth and 38.82% year-over-year increase in building permits.

Raleigh offers a unique combination of a highly skilled workforce, rapid job growth, and an affordable cost of living, making it an excellent location for companies. The primary risk is labor availability becoming a significant constraint due to the tight labor market and slow labor force growth, which could limit the city's ability to sustain its current pace of economic expansion.

Las Vegas

Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas

A+

EXCELLENT

68.8th percentile

Rank 3 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

5.2%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+6.7%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+1.7%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

N/A

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-9.8%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

52 days

median, +18.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Las Vegas earns an A+ grade, driven by its exceptional labor market growth of 3.24% year-over-year. The city's labor force growth is accompanied by strong wage growth, with hourly earnings rising 6.67% year-over-year, and nonfarm employment growth of 1.70% year-over-year. This rapid job creation is a key indicator of the city's economic expansion.

The unemployment rate is 5.20%, indicating labor market slack, and the days on market for homes has increased by 18.2% year-over-year, with an average of 52 days. This slowing pace in the housing market introduces some uncertainty, despite the strong employment growth. The city has a deep professional talent pool, ranking in the 86th percentile for office and professional worker share.

Las Vegas offers businesses a thriving labor market with strong job growth and a skilled workforce, making it an attractive location for companies seeking to expand. The presence of a deep professional talent pool is a significant advantage for knowledge-economy businesses, but the elevated unemployment rate and slowing housing market are factors to consider when making location decisions, with the city's overall economic character supporting its A+ grade.

Hartford

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford

A+

EXCELLENT

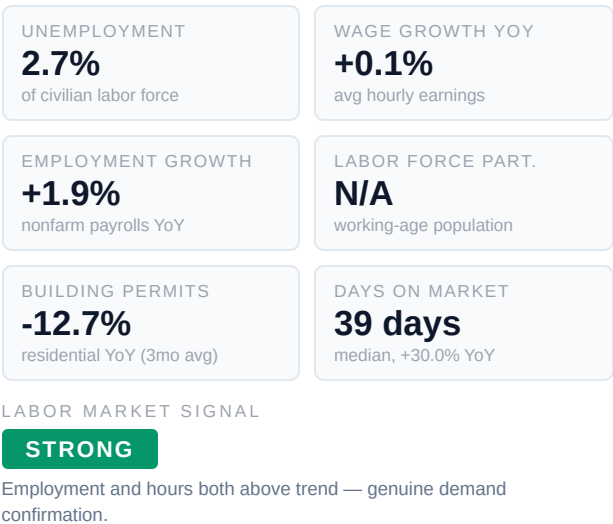
68.8th percentile

Rank 4 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Hartford earns an A+ grade, driven by its remarkably tight labor market with an unemployment rate of 2.70% and a labor force growing at a rate of 2.77% year-over-year. This robust labor market, combined with nonfarm employment growth of 1.88% year-over-year, makes it an attractive location for businesses looking to tap into a skilled and growing workforce.

The city's labor market strength is offset by stagnant wage growth, with hourly earnings increasing by only 0.13% year-over-year, a bottom-tier performance. This raises concerns about the sustainability of the labor market's strength and the potential for workforce attraction and retention challenges. The housing market is also slowing, with days on market increasing by 30.0% year-over-year to an average of 39 days, and a decline in building permits of 12.70% year-over-year, indicating a potential housing supply squeeze.

Hartford's strong job growth and low unemployment rate make it an excellent location for talent acquisition and expansion. However, stagnant wage growth and a potential housing supply squeeze pose significant risks to its long-term economic viability and attractiveness to businesses and workers alike, with the housing market showing signs of slowing and potential affordability issues.

Salt Lake City

Salt Lake City-Murray

A

VERY GOOD

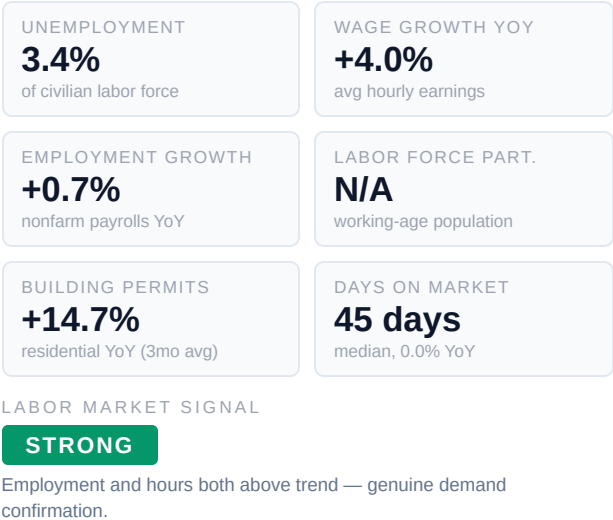
64.1th percentile

Rank 5 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Salt Lake City earns an overall grade of A, driven by its strong economic character and top-tier nonfarm employment growth of +0.74% YoY. The city's deep professional talent pool, ranking in the 94th percentile for office and professional worker concentration, supports this momentum. The labor force growth of +0.62% YoY is below average, but the strong employment growth indicates a thriving economy.

The housing market is competitive, with homes selling at an average of 45 days on market and a 0.0% YoY change, indicating no slowdown. Above-average building permits growth of +14.73% YoY drives a genuine demand surge, fueled by employment growth. The cost of living is above average, with a score of 1.85, and may become a concern if the housing market continues to heat up.

Salt Lake City offers businesses a thriving economy with rapid job creation, but the competitive housing market poses a risk for relocating workers to secure affordable housing, potentially affecting talent attraction and retention. The city's strong economic character and deep professional talent pool make it an attractive location, despite the housing market challenges.

Austin

Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos

A

VERY GOOD

64.0th percentile

Rank 6 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos earns an overall grade of A, driven by its strong economic character. The city's low unemployment rate of 3.20% and solid wage growth of 5.84% year-over-year indicate a healthy labor market, conducive to consumer spending and business growth. Its cost of living composite score of 1.04 makes it one of the most affordable metros, offering a strong cost advantage for businesses and residents.

The city's office and professional worker share is exceptionally high, ranking in the 96th percentile. However, the sharp decline in building permits of -29.44% year-over-year raises concerns about future affordability and workforce attraction. The days on market have increased by 20.4% year-over-year, with homes now taking an average of 53 days to sell, indicating a slowing market.

Austin offers businesses a unique combination of a skilled workforce, affordable cost of living, and solid wage growth, making it an attractive location for knowledge-economy businesses. The primary risk lies in the city's constrained housing supply, which will lead to future affordability stress and workforce attraction difficulties, potentially undermining its economic advantages.

Birmingham

Birmingham

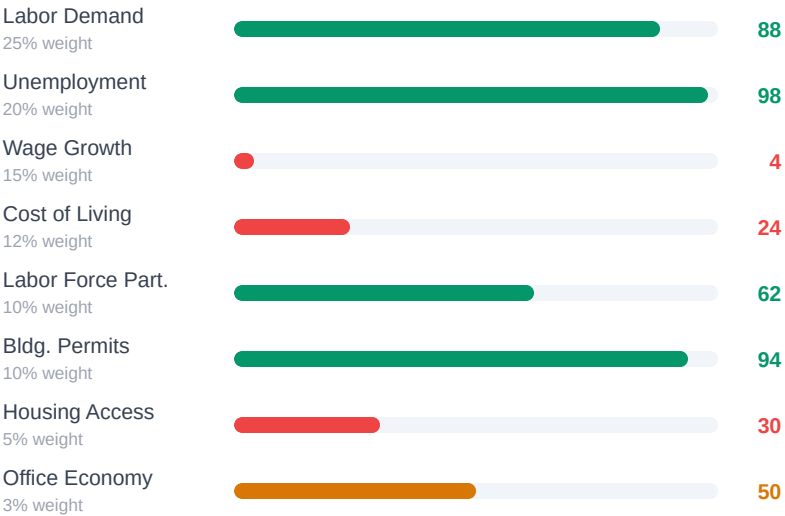
A

VERY GOOD

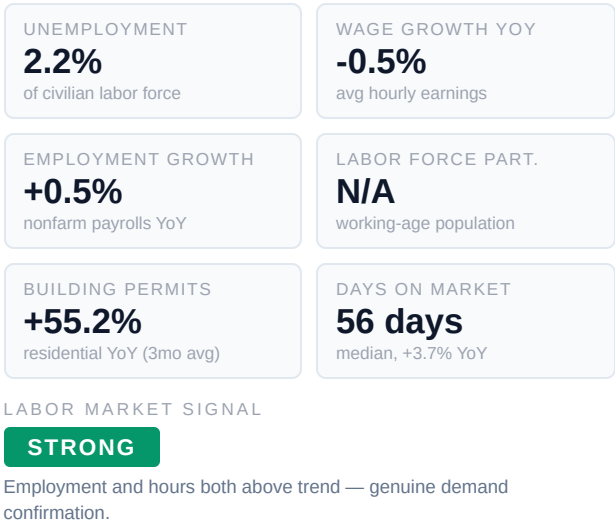
63.7th percentile

Rank 7 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Birmingham earns an A grade, driven by its strong labor market with an unemployment rate of 2.20% and a 0.52% year-over-year increase in nonfarm employment. This indicates intense competition for hiring and significant leverage for workers. The city's 63.7th percentile ranking out of 50 US metros underscores its attractiveness as a business location.

The city's housing market is competitive, with homes selling at an average of 56 days on the market, although days on market have increased by 3.7% year-over-year. A 55.25% year-over-year increase in building permits indicates aggressive expansion of housing supply. This growth, combined with strong employment numbers, supports the city's economic momentum.

Birmingham offers businesses a dynamic and expanding economy, making it an attractive location for those willing to compete for talent. However, stagnant wage growth, with a -0.46% year-over-year change, poses a risk to consumer spending and the sustainability of the city's economic momentum.

Dallas

Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington

A-

GOOD

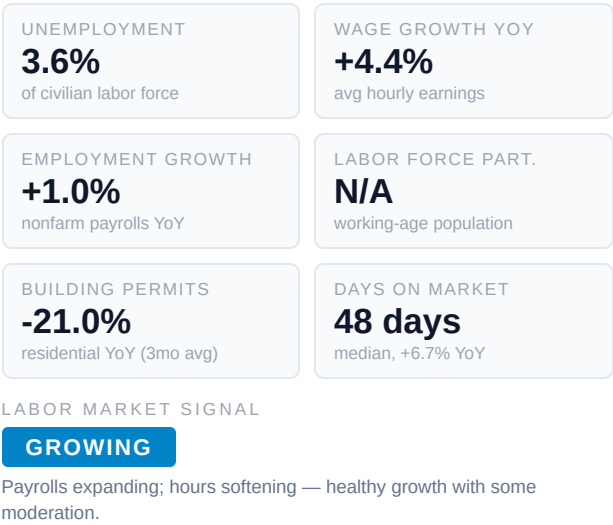
62.9th percentile

Rank 8 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Dallas earns an overall grade of A- and ranks in the 62.9th percentile out of 50 US metros, driven by its strong economic character. The city boasts a healthy labor market, with an unemployment rate of 3.60% and above-average nonfarm employment growth of 0.98% year-over-year. Its cost of living composite score is 1.30, placing it in the top tier of affordability.

The city's office and professional worker share is exceptionally high, ranking in the 92nd percentile, indicating a deep talent pool that could support knowledge-economy businesses. However, the sharp decline in building permits, down 20.96% year-over-year, indicates a looming housing supply squeeze. This decline is particularly concerning given the strong employment growth, as it will lead to affordability and workforce attraction issues.

Dallas offers businesses a unique combination of a strong labor market, affordable cost of living, and deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for companies. The primary risk is the potential housing supply squeeze, which could erode the city's affordability advantage and create challenges for workforce attraction, making it essential for businesses to consider these factors in their location decision.

Nashville

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin

A-

GOOD

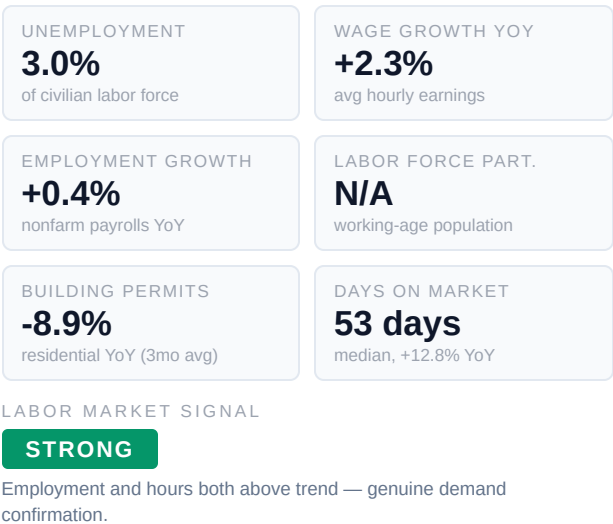
61.8th percentile

Rank 9 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Nashville earns an overall grade of A-, driven by its exceptionally strong labor market. The city's unemployment rate of 3.0% indicates a tight labor market, where businesses face significant hiring competition and workers have leverage. The labor force is growing rapidly, with a year-over-year increase of 3.42%, signaling an expanding workforce supply.

The presence of a high concentration of office and professional workers, ranking in the 90th percentile, makes Nashville an attractive location for knowledge-economy businesses and headquarters. Nonfarm employment is growing at an above-average rate of 0.41% year-over-year, further solidifying the city's strong labor market. However, wage growth is sluggish, with hourly earnings increasing by only 2.31% year-over-year, which indicates weak worker bargaining power or softening demand.

Nashville's unique combination of a tight labor market, rapid labor force growth, and a deep professional talent pool makes it an attractive location for knowledge-economy businesses. The exceptionally low unemployment rate and slow wage growth pose a risk, as businesses may face hiring challenges and upward pressure on wages, impacting their ability to attract and retain top talent.

Atlanta

Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell

A-

GOOD

59.5th percentile

Rank 10 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.3%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+6.5%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.1%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

N/A

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-30.9%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

51 days

median, +8.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Atlanta earns an overall grade of A- and ranks in the 59.5th percentile among 50 US metros, with its low unemployment rate of 3.30% and top-tier wage growth of 6.47% driving a healthy labor market. The labor force is growing slowly, with a year-over-year growth rate of only 0.51%, which constrains hiring capacity. This slow growth, combined with a tight unemployment rate, indicates a shrinking workforce rather than just low layoffs.

The city's housing supply is a concern, with building permits declining sharply by 30.90% year-over-year, indicating a contracting housing supply. This decline, combined with a moderate days-on-market increase of 8.5% year-over-year, indicates a potential demand erosion scenario. Atlanta has a cost of living composite score of 1.53, ranking in the 76th percentile, and an above-average professional workforce, ranking in the 68th percentile.

Atlanta offers businesses a talented and affordable workforce, with a low unemployment rate and high wage growth. However, the city's constrained housing supply and potential demand erosion pose a primary risk, impacting workforce attraction and affordability in the long run. The city's slow labor force growth and tight unemployment rate also pose challenges for businesses looking to hire and expand.

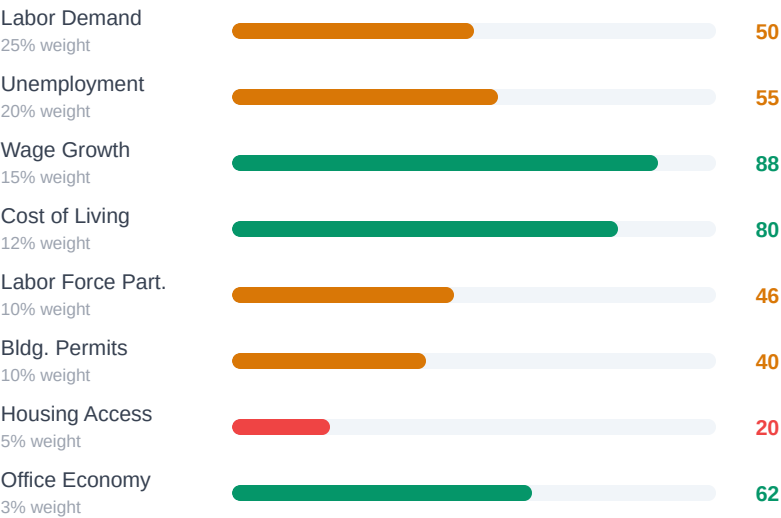
Pittsburgh

Pittsburgh

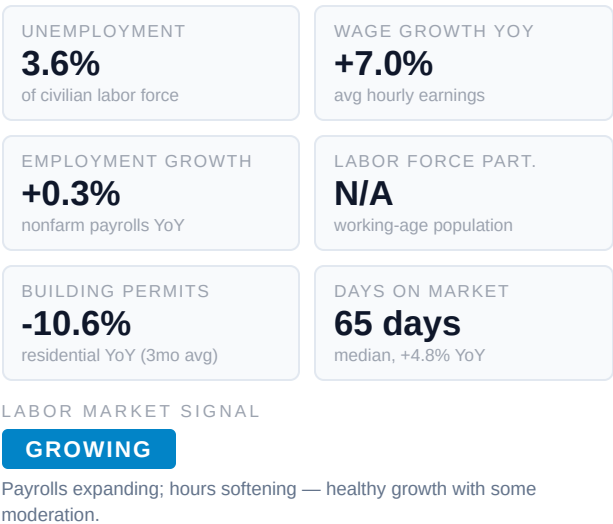
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
57.8th percentile
Rank 11 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Pittsburgh earns a B+ grade, with its 7.00% year-over-year wage growth being a top-tier metric that indicates a strong labor market with rising incomes. The city's cost of living composite score is 1.44, signifying a below-average cost of living, which makes Pittsburgh attractive to workers and businesses. The office and professional worker share ranks in the 62nd percentile, indicating a skilled and professional workforce.

The housing market is slowing down, with days on market increasing by 4.8% year-over-year, despite homes selling in an average of 65 days. This slowing demand is a sign of normalization in the market and raises questions about the sustainability of the city's economic momentum. The tension between the strong labor market and the slowing housing market is a key consideration for businesses looking to locate in Pittsburgh.

Pittsburgh offers businesses a unique combination of a skilled workforce, rising incomes, and a low cost of living. The slowing housing market poses a risk, potentially signaling a broader economic slowdown that could impact businesses' ability to attract and retain talent, with the city's economic momentum hanging in the balance.

Los Angeles

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
55.8th percentile
Rank 12 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim earns a B+ grade, driven by its top-tier nonfarm employment growth of +1.83% YoY and solid wage growth of +5.44% YoY. The city's labor market is thriving, with rapid job creation and increasing consumer spending power. The cost of living composite is 5.65, ranking in the bottom tier, which poses a significant constraint on talent acquisition and real consumer spending power.

The strong job market and rising wages are positives, but the high cost of living threatens to erode the city's attractiveness to businesses and workers. The housing market is showing signs of stabilization, with building permits increasing by +20.24% YoY, which could help alleviate some of the affordability pressures. Homes are taking 7.1% more days to sell than last year, averaging 45 days.

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim offers a dynamic and expanding economy with a strong labor market, but at a high cost. The city's extremely high cost of living limits the appeal of the market to businesses and workers, potentially constraining long-term growth and profitability.

Denver

Denver-Aurora-Centennial

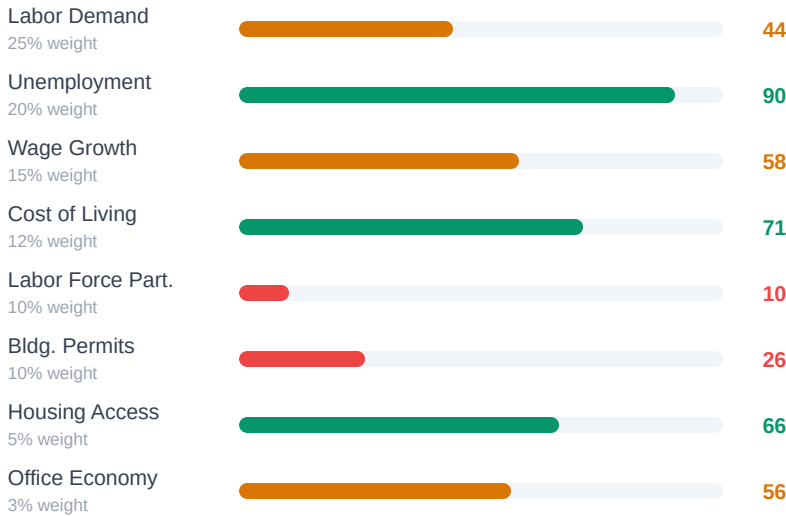
B

AVERAGE

54.8th percentile

Rank 13 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.6%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+4.7%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.1%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

N/A

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-16.0%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

38 days

median, +8.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Denver earns an overall grade of B, with its exceptionally low unemployment rate of 3.60% being the single most important takeaway about this city. The city's tight labor market gives workers considerable leverage, but businesses face significant hiring competition. The civilian labor force has contracted by 1.50% year-over-year, indicating a structural headwind for businesses seeking to expand their headcount.

The city's housing market is tightening, with building permits declining by 15.96% year-over-year. Homes are taking longer to sell, with days on market increasing by 8.6% year-over-year to an average of 38 days. Denver's cost of living is below average, with a composite score of 1.69. The housing market slowdown is a sign of demand erosion, particularly given the weak employment growth and declining labor force.

Denver offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market and a below-average cost of living, but the primary risk is the shrinking workforce and tightening housing supply. The city's economic character is defined by its exceptionally low unemployment rate and below-average cost of living, making it an attractive location for businesses. However, the declining labor force and slowing housing market pose significant challenges for companies looking to expand their operations, with the city ranking in the 54.8th percentile out of 50 US metros.

Phoenix

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler

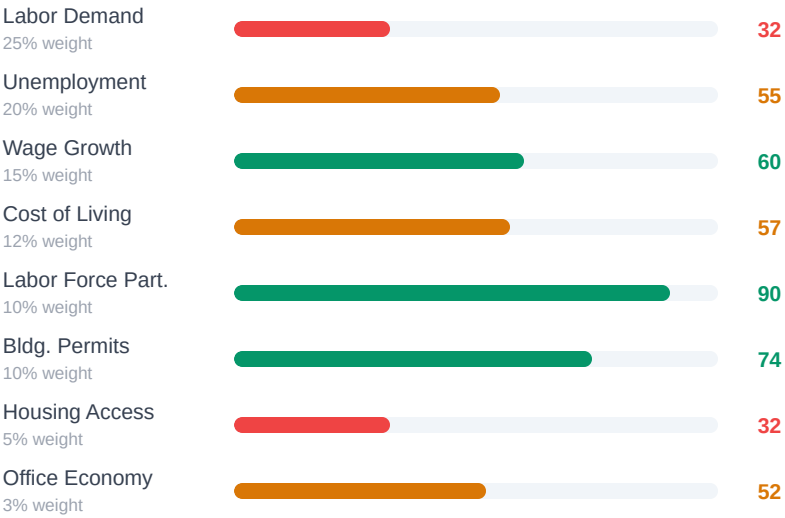
B

AVERAGE

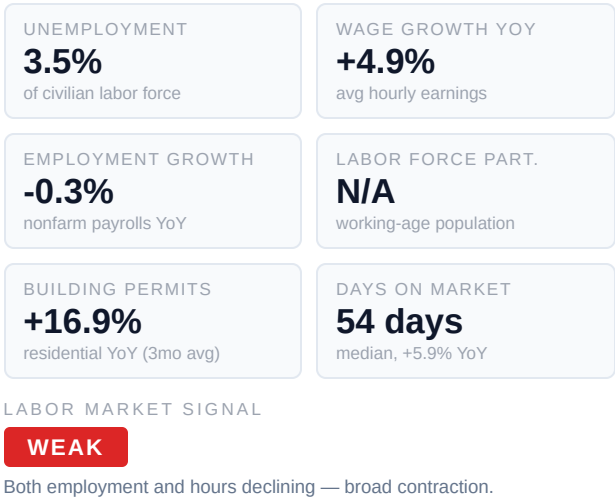
54.4th percentile

Rank 14 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Phoenix earns a B grade, with a 54.4th percentile ranking out of 50 US metros, driven by strong growth in the civilian labor force, which has expanded by 2.36% year-over-year. The labor force growth indicates a rapidly increasing workforce supply. Nonfarm employment growth is -0.28% year-over-year, which is below average and indicates economic deceleration.

The housing market is experiencing above-average building permit growth of 16.86% year-over-year, but days on market have increased by 5.9% year-over-year, with homes now taking an average of 54 days to sell. This slowdown in the housing market, combined with weak employment growth, indicates demand erosion. Labor force growth and solid wage growth of 4.87% year-over-year are positives.

Phoenix offers businesses a rapidly expanding workforce and solid wage growth, but the primary risk lies in potential demand erosion in the housing market, which could signal broader economic softness. Decision-makers should weigh the benefits of a growing labor force against the potential risks of a slowing economy, particularly in the context of the city's housing market dynamics, to make informed decisions about investing in Phoenix.

Cincinnati

Cincinnati

B

AVERAGE

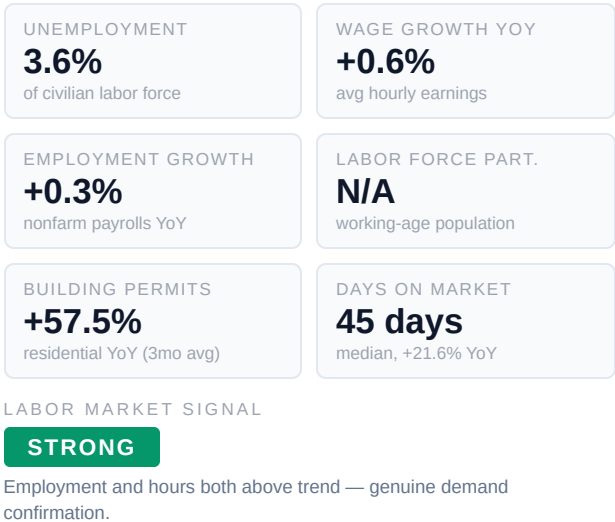
53.6th percentile

Rank 15 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cincinnati earns a B grade, with its exceptionally low unemployment rate of 3.60% being the most important takeaway. The city's tight labor market gives workers considerable leverage, but also poses significant hiring competition for businesses. The civilian labor force has contracted by 0.79% year-over-year, indicating a structural headwind for businesses seeking to expand their headcount. Wage growth has been stagnant, with hourly earnings increasing by only 0.55% year-over-year, undermining consumer spending power.

The city's housing market is expanding, with building permits surging by 57.47% year-over-year. However, homes are taking longer to sell, with days on market increasing by 21.6% year-over-year to an average of 45 days. Cincinnati has a deep professional talent pool, ranking in the 82nd percentile for office and professional worker share, which is a significant advantage for knowledge-economy businesses.

Cincinnati offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market and an expanding housing supply, making it an attractive location for companies seeking to tap into a skilled workforce. The primary risk lies in the city's shrinking labor force and stagnant wage growth, which constrains businesses' ability to expand and attract talent, potentially undermining the city's long-term economic momentum.

Houston

Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands

B

AVERAGE

53.5th percentile

Rank 16 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		54
25% weight		
Unemployment		37
20% weight		
Wage Growth		52
15% weight		
Cost of Living		96
12% weight		
Labor Force Part.		54
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		32
10% weight		
Housing Access		60
5% weight		
Office Economy		58
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 4.2% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +4.1% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.7% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE PART. N/A working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS -12.9% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 50 days median, +11.1% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Houston earns a B grade, with its cost of living composite score of 1.02 ranking in the 96th percentile, making it one of the most affordable metros in the dataset. This affordability offers a strong cost advantage with lower real-wage requirements and higher consumer purchasing power. The city's unemployment rate is 4.20%, signaling labor market slack and weakened local consumer demand.

The housing market shows signs of slowing, with days on market increasing by 11.1% year-over-year, and homes now taking an average of 50 days to sell, ranking in the 60th percentile. Building permit growth is -12.89%, below average, indicating demand erosion rather than a healthy normalization. This is consistent with the city's average employment growth, which fails to offset the declining permit activity.

Houston offers businesses an attractive cost structure, with its high affordability ranking being a major draw. However, the potential demand erosion in the housing market poses a risk, as it could signal broader economic softness and impact local consumer demand. Decision-makers must carefully weigh these factors in their location decision, considering the city's overall grade of B, or 53.5th percentile out of 50 US metros.

Memphis

Memphis

B

AVERAGE

53.5th percentile

Rank 17 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.0%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+6.1%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.3%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

N/A

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+19.7%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

62 days

median, +6.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Memphis earns an overall grade of B, with its stagnant job market, at -0.35% year-over-year nonfarm employment growth, being the most significant concern. The city's labor force growth is 1.36% and wage growth is 6.12%, indicating that the existing workforce is experiencing wage increases. The combination of these factors shows a market where the workforce is growing and earning more, but the job market is not expanding.

The city's cost of living is highly affordable, ranked in the 98th percentile, but its housing market is slow, with days on market increasing by 6.9% year-over-year to an average of 62 days. This slowdown is consistent with the weak employment growth. The city's low concentration of office and professional workers, ranked in the 0th percentile, poses a significant constraint for knowledge-economy businesses.

Memphis offers businesses an affordable cost of living and a growing labor force, with above-average building permit growth of 19.69% year-over-year. However, its stagnant job market and limited professional workforce pose significant risks. The city's softening demand and limited access to skilled workers could hinder long-term growth and success for businesses considering locating in Memphis.

Fresno

Fresno

B

AVERAGE

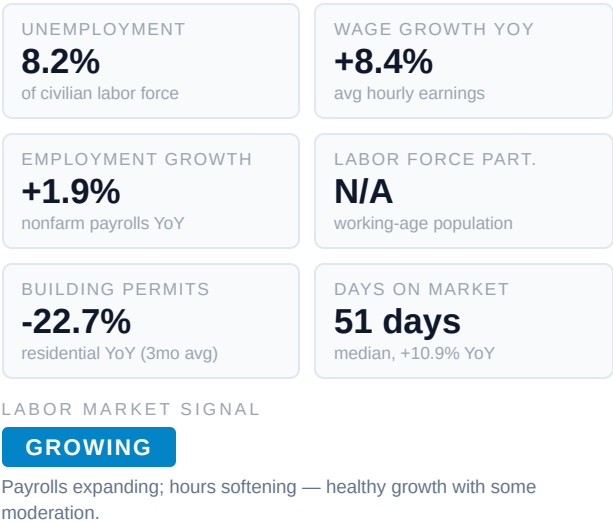
53.5th percentile

Rank 18 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Fresno earns an overall grade of B, with its most important takeaway being rapid job creation amidst severe labor market weakness. With nonfarm employment growth at +1.86% YoY and labor force growth at +1.87% YoY, the city is experiencing an economically expanding market. The unemployment rate of 8.20% indicates that job growth has not been enough to absorb the existing labor force, posing a significant consumer spending risk.

The city's data reveals tensions, including a sharp decline in building permits, down 22.67% YoY, which signals a potential housing supply squeeze and affordability stress. This could lead to workforce attraction difficulties. The low concentration of professional and office workers, ranking in the 4th percentile, poses a significant constraint for knowledge-economy businesses.

Fresno's rapid wage growth of +8.37% YoY presents a labor cost pressure for employers, while being excellent for workers. The city's severe labor market weakness and low professional worker concentration pose significant challenges. Businesses must carefully consider these factors when making location decisions, as Fresno offers an economically expanding market with rapid job creation, but also potential risks such as a housing supply squeeze and affordability stress.

San Jose

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara

B

AVERAGE

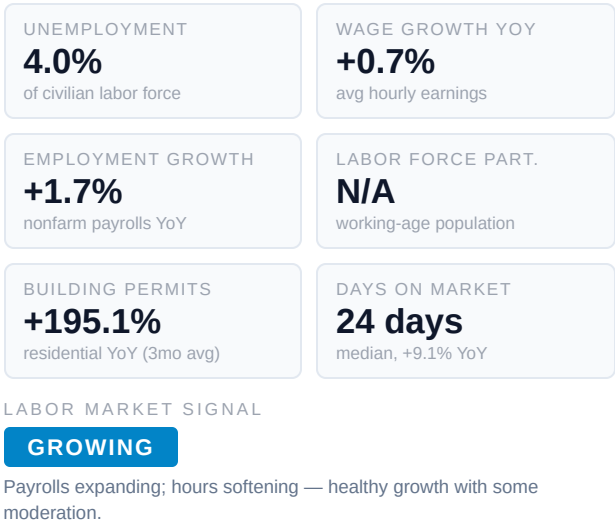
51.4th percentile

Rank 19 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

San Jose earns a top-tier grade due to its rapid job creation, with nonfarm employment growth at +1.69% year-over-year. The city's deep professional talent pool, ranked in the 88th percentile for office and professional worker share, supports this momentum. However, wage growth remains stagnant at +0.65% year-over-year, a bottom-tier performance.

The city's cost of living is a significant constraint, with a composite score of 5.76, making it one of the most expensive metros. The housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by 9.1% year-over-year to 24 days. This slowdown is a healthy normalization, given the strong employment growth and a 195.09% year-over-year increase in building permits.

San Jose offers businesses a unique combination of a deep professional talent pool and rapid job creation, making it an attractive location for knowledge-economy businesses. The high cost of living constrains talent acquisition and real consumer spending power, making it essential for businesses to carefully consider compensation packages and relocation support.

San Francisco

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont

B

AVERAGE

50.5th percentile

Rank 20 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

San Francisco earns an overall grade of B, with its strong wage growth of 5.54% year-over-year being the most important takeaway. The city's above-average nonfarm employment growth and solid wage growth indicate a healthy expansion, with a strong demand for labor. San Francisco's cost of living composite score is 4.53, making it one of the most expensive metros, which constrains talent acquisition and real consumer spending power.

The housing market is extremely competitive, with homes selling in just 29 days on average, a pace that is speeding up by 6.5% year-over-year. This fast-moving market, combined with the high cost of living, poses a significant relocation challenge for new hires. The city's below-average office and professional worker share raises concerns about the availability of specialized or senior talent.

San Francisco offers businesses a strong and growing economy with a highly paid workforce, but the primary risk is the high cost of living and extremely competitive housing market, which can make it difficult to attract and retain talent. Companies must carefully weigh the benefits of San Francisco's economic growth against the challenges of operating in one of the most expensive cities in the country, with a cost of living composite score of 4.53.

Charlotte

Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia

B

AVERAGE

50.2th percentile

Rank 21 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.6%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

-1.3%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.8%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

N/A

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-39.5%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

49 days

median, +13.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Charlotte earns a B grade, ranking 50.2th percentile out of 50 US metros, with its strong labor force growth being the most important takeaway. The city's labor force has grown 2.28% year-over-year, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to hire. Nonfarm employment growth is also above-average, at 0.85% year-over-year, indicating a healthy expansion.

A key tension in Charlotte's economy is the mismatch between strong employment growth and a sharply declining housing supply, with building permits plummeting 39.50% year-over-year. This discrepancy will lead to affordability and workforce attraction issues in the future. The city's housing market is slowing, with homes taking 13.9% more days to sell than last year, resulting in an average of 49 days on market.

Charlotte offers businesses a strong and growing labor force, but stagnant wages, which have declined 1.28% year-over-year, and a declining housing supply pose future challenges. The primary risk for businesses locating in Charlotte is the potential for affordability and workforce attraction issues to deteriorate, making it essential to carefully consider these factors in location decisions.

Columbus

Columbus

B

AVERAGE

50.1th percentile

Rank 22 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		24
25% weight		
Unemployment		78
20% weight		
Wage Growth		32
15% weight		
Cost of Living		67
12% weight		
Labor Force Part.		27
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		66
10% weight		
Housing Access		84
5% weight		
Office Economy		74
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.6% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +3.0% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.3% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE PART. N/A working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS +8.7% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 41 days median, +10.8% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Columbus earns an overall grade of B, with its low unemployment rate of 3.60% being the single most important takeaway about this city. The city's labor force growth is 0.35% YoY and nonfarm employment growth is 0.29% YoY, indicating a constructive but constrained market. The cost of living is affordable, with a composite score of 1.85.

The days on market for homes has increased by 10.8% YoY, with an average of 41 days, placing it in the top tier. This indicates a slowing housing market, likely due to softening demand rather than a healthy normalization, given the weak employment growth. Columbus has an above-average office and professional worker share, ranking in the 74th percentile.

Columbus offers a business an affordable cost of living and a skilled workforce, but the primary risk lies in its slowing economic growth and potential demand erosion. The city's sluggish job growth and increasing days on market for homes signal a cautionary note for businesses considering location decisions, as they may face challenges in attracting and retaining talent in a stagnant labor market.

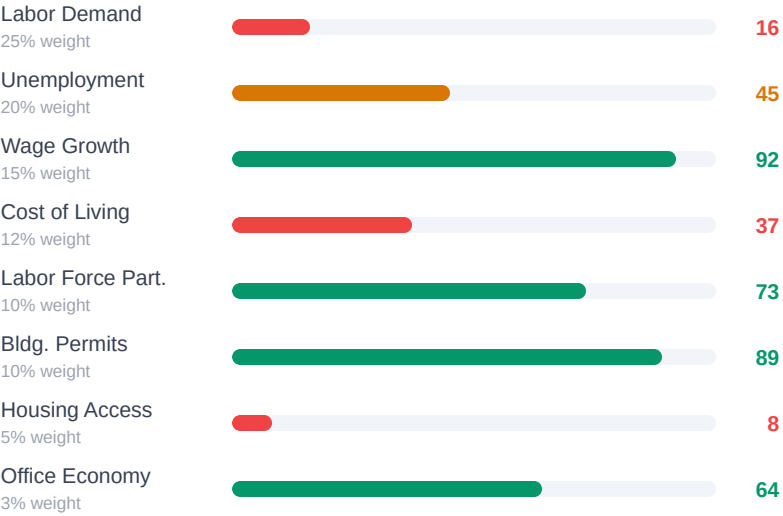
Miami

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach

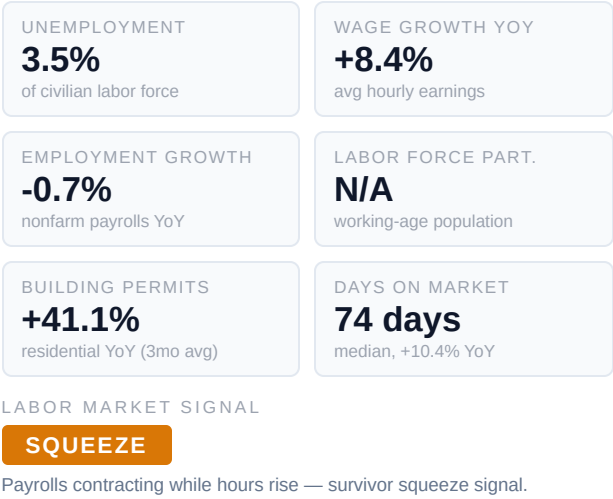
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
49.7th percentile
Rank 23 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Miami earns a below-average overall grade of 49.7th percentile, with its most notable feature being rapid wage growth amidst stagnant employment. The city's nonfarm employment growth is in contraction, with a -0.70% year-over-year change, indicating job losses or near-stagnation. Hourly earnings are rising by 8.39% year-over-year, a top-tier performance.

The labor force is growing at a moderate pace of 1.40% year-over-year, which is a positive sign for workforce supply. However, the housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by 10.4% year-over-year to 74 days, indicating demand erosion. Building permits are up 41.11% year-over-year, suggesting that housing supply is expanding aggressively, which could help alleviate affordability pressures.

Miami's combination of rapid wage growth and expanding housing supply could attract businesses looking to tap into a skilled workforce. However, the city's stagnant employment growth, with a -0.70% year-over-year change, poses a primary risk, potentially limiting the pool of available talent and making it challenging to scale operations.

New York

New York Newark-Jersey City

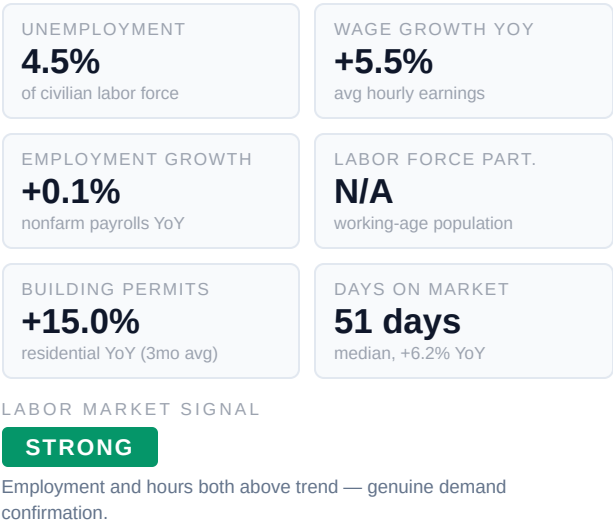
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
49.6th percentile
Rank 24 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

New York earns a grade of B+ due to its strong labor market, with nonfarm employment increasing by 0.13% year-over-year and a 1.20% year-over-year growth in the civilian labor force. The city's solid wage growth of 5.47% year-over-year is a positive indicator of economic health. However, the unemployment rate is 4.50%, indicating labor market slack.

The city's high cost of living, with a composite index score of 4.95, limits the impact of wage growth on workers' real purchasing power. The housing market is characterized by above-average building permit growth of 14.97% year-over-year, and days on market are increasing by 6.2% year-over-year, with an average of 51 days. This suggests a stabilizing force in the market, given the strong employment growth and permit activity.

New York offers a strong and expanding labor market with solid wage growth, but at a high cost of living. The city's extremely high cost of living limits the real benefits of wage growth and talent acquisition, making it essential for businesses to carefully consider the trade-offs of operating in this market, where the high cost of living is a primary risk.

Cleveland

Cleveland

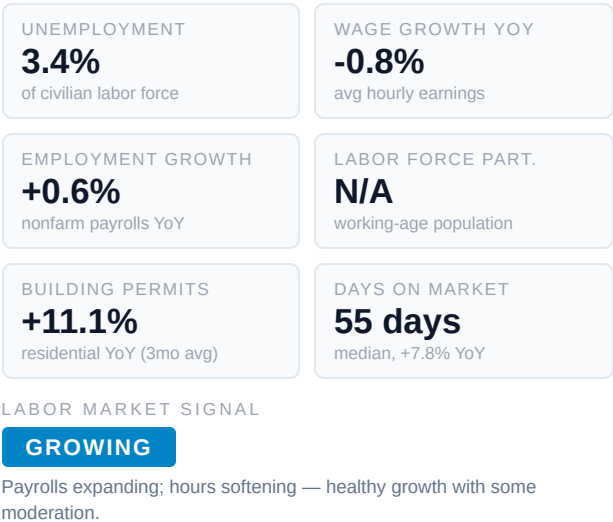
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
49.3th percentile
Rank 25 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cleveland earns a B+ grade, with its strong 1.80% year-over-year labor force growth being the most important takeaway. This growth indicates a rapidly expanding workforce supply, with 1.80% year-over-year increase. The city's workforce is growing, but wages are declining, with a -0.77% year-over-year change in hourly earnings, limiting workers' leverage.

The housing market is characterized by a 11.14% year-over-year increase in building permits, keeping pace with demand, and an average of 55 days to sell homes, with days on market increasing by 7.8% year-over-year. The city has an above-average professional workforce, ranking in the 76th percentile, which is a positive for office-dependent businesses.

Cleveland offers businesses a growing workforce and a professional workforce concentration, but declining wages and a slowing housing market pose a risk. The city's economic momentum is uncertain, making it essential for businesses to carefully consider these factors when making location decisions, weighing the benefits of a growing workforce against the drawbacks of a softening market.

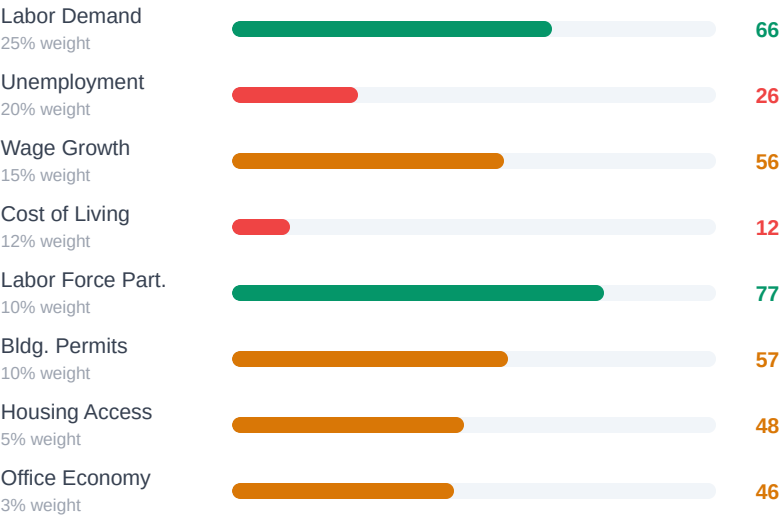
San Diego

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad

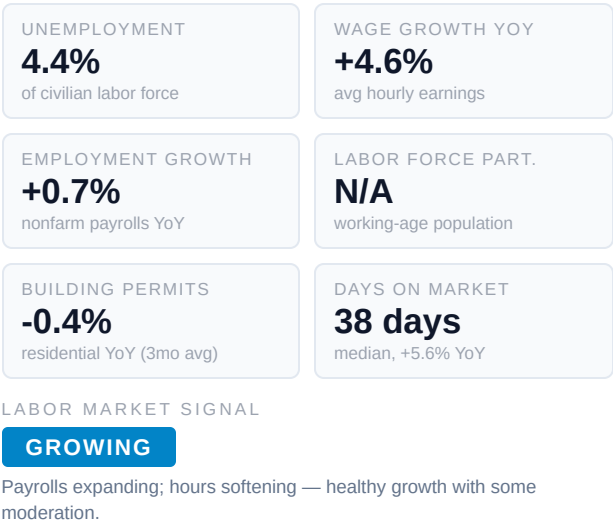
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
48.9th percentile
Rank 26 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

San Diego earns a below-average overall grade, driven by its high cost of living, with a composite score of 4.92, and elevated unemployment at 4.40%. The city boasts above-average job growth, with nonfarm employment increasing by 0.70% year-over-year, and a growing labor force, up 1.66% year-over-year. This combination of factors indicates a market with slack in the labor force and economic expansion.

The city's expensive cost of living poses a risk to talent acquisition and real consumer spending power. Homes take an average of 38 days to sell, 5.6% more days than last year, and building permits are down 0.37% year-over-year. This slowing housing market signals a normalization of the market, but also raises concerns about demand erosion.

San Diego offers businesses a growing labor force and above-average job growth, but at a high cost of living that constrains talent acquisition and consumer spending. The city's expensive cost of living and slowing housing market weaken the local economy, making it essential for businesses to carefully weigh the benefits and drawbacks of locating in San Diego, considering its 4.40% unemployment rate and 4.92 composite cost of living score.

Providence

Providence-Warwick

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
48.7th percentile
Rank 27 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		74
Unemployment 20% weight		14
Wage Growth 15% weight		28
Cost of Living 12% weight		0
Labor Force Part. 10% weight		79
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		85
Housing Access 5% weight		94
Office Economy 3% weight		66

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 4.3% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +2.8% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.6% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE PART. N/A working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS +23.5% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 48 days median, +33.3% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Providence earns a grade of C+ due to its struggling labor market, with an unemployment rate of 4.30% indicating severe labor market weakness and flagging consumer spending risk. The city's high cost of living, with a composite index of 7.36, is a significant constraint on talent acquisition and real consumer spending power, making it one of the most expensive metros. Nonfarm employment is increasing by 0.60% year-over-year, signaling a healthy expansion.

The city's housing market is experiencing a slowdown in home sales, with days on market increasing by 33.3% year-over-year to an average of 48 days, indicating a slow and buyer-friendly market. Building permits are rising by 23.50% year-over-year, indicating a healthy normalization of the market rather than demand erosion. The presence of an above-average professional workforce, ranking in the 66th percentile, is a positive for office-dependent businesses.

Providence offers businesses a unique combination of a highly educated workforce and a slowing housing market, providing opportunities for relocation and growth. The city's extremely high cost of living, with a composite index of 7.36, constrains talent acquisition and consumer spending power, making it essential for businesses to carefully consider these factors when making location decisions. With an unemployment rate of 4.30% and nonfarm employment growth of 0.60%, businesses must weigh these factors against the city's other advantages.

Philadelphia

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
47.8th percentile
Rank 28 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		72
Unemployment 20% weight		26
Wage Growth 15% weight		20
Cost of Living 12% weight		35
Labor Force Part. 10% weight		54
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		62
Housing Access 5% weight		82
Office Economy 3% weight		54

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 4.0% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +1.6% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.3% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE PART. N/A working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS +4.1% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 43 days median, +10.3% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Philadelphia earns a B- grade, with its above-average nonfarm employment growth of +0.27% YoY being the single most important takeaway about this city. The city's employment growth indicates a healthy expansion, with a growing number of jobs available. However, an elevated unemployment rate of 4.00% indicates labor market slack and weakened local consumer demand. Sluggish wage growth of +1.61% YoY signals a lower cost environment for employers, but also raises concerns about worker bargaining power and demand.

The housing market is slowing, with homes taking 43 days to sell and a +10.3% YoY increase in days on market. This scenario indicates a healthy normalization of the market, where buyers are gaining negotiating room and affordability pressure is moderating. The city's cost of living composite score of 3.26 indicates a below-average cost of living, supporting this interpretation.

Philadelphia offers businesses a growing job market and an affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for companies looking to expand. The primary risk is the potential for weakened local consumer demand due to labor market slack and sluggish wage growth, which could impact businesses reliant on local spending.

Louisville

Louisville-Jefferson County

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
47.4th percentile
Rank 29 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
3.1%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+2.4%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
-0.2%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.
N/A
working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS
+3.0%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
45 days
median, +9.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Louisville earns a B+ grade, with its exceptionally low unemployment rate of 3.10% being the most important takeaway about this city. The city's labor market is characterized by a tight hiring environment where workers have leverage, but this is paired with below-average labor force growth of 0.38% YoY and sluggish nonfarm employment growth of -0.24% YoY, indicating a shallow pool of available workers and a decelerating economy.

The city's low office and professional worker concentration, ranking in the 18th percentile, constrains its appeal to knowledge-economy businesses. The slow labor force growth and weak employment growth signal a potential shortage of skilled workers, making it challenging for businesses to find and retain talent. The housing market is moderating, with above-average days on market of 45 days and a 9.8% YoY increase, which is a sign of softening demand given the weak employment growth.

Louisville's below-average cost of living composite of 3.38 means that businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent, complicating the hiring landscape. The city's shallow labor pool, slow employment growth, and low professional worker concentration pose significant risks for businesses, and the potential for talent shortages and hiring challenges may outweigh the benefits of the city's low cost of living and moderating housing market.

Boston

Boston-Cambridge-Newton

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
47.1th percentile
Rank 30 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		68
Unemployment 20% weight		20
Wage Growth 15% weight		36
Cost of Living 12% weight		16
Labor Force Part. 10% weight		94
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		30
Housing Access 5% weight		78
Office Economy 3% weight		80

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.9% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +3.4% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.7% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE PART. N/A working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS -15.0% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 30 days median, +20.0% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Boston's economy, graded a B-, is characterized by a strong labor force growth rate of 2.87% year-over-year. The city's labor force is expanding rapidly, with a nonfarm employment growth rate of 0.73% year-over-year, signaling a healthy expansion. This growth is accompanied by an unemployment rate of 3.90%, indicating some labor market slack.

The city's cost of living is a significant concern, with a composite score of 4.38 placing it in the bottom tier. This high cost of living, combined with wage growth of 3.37% year-over-year, constrains talent acquisition and consumer spending power. The housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by 20% year-over-year to an average of 30 days, and building permits declining by 14.97% year-over-year.

Boston offers businesses a deep professional talent pool, with an office and professional worker share ranking in the 80th percentile. The city's high cost of living erodes the purchasing power of employees and constrains business growth, posing a primary risk to businesses operating in the area.

Seattle

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue

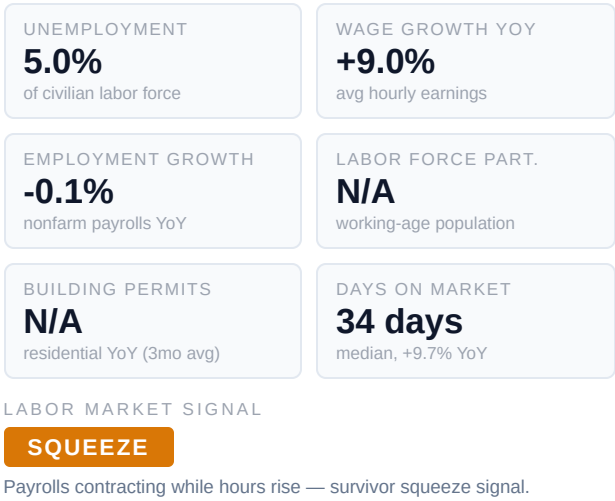
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
45.8th percentile
Rank 31 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Seattle earns a B+ grade, with its labor market weakness being the most critical concern. The city's unemployment rate of 5.00% flags potential consumer spending risks. Wages are rising fast, with a 9.02% year-over-year increase, posing a real cost pressure for employers. The housing market is characterized by homes taking 34 days to sell on average, which is extremely fast, but also slowing down with a 9.7% year-over-year increase in days on market. The city's above-average professional workforce, ranking in the 60th percentile, is a positive for office-dependent businesses. Seattle offers a highly skilled workforce and a competitive wage environment, but labor market weakness poses a significant risk to consumer spending and business growth. The rapid wage growth benefits workers but also poses a significant cost pressure for employers, making it essential for businesses to carefully consider these factors when making location decisions.

Riverside

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario

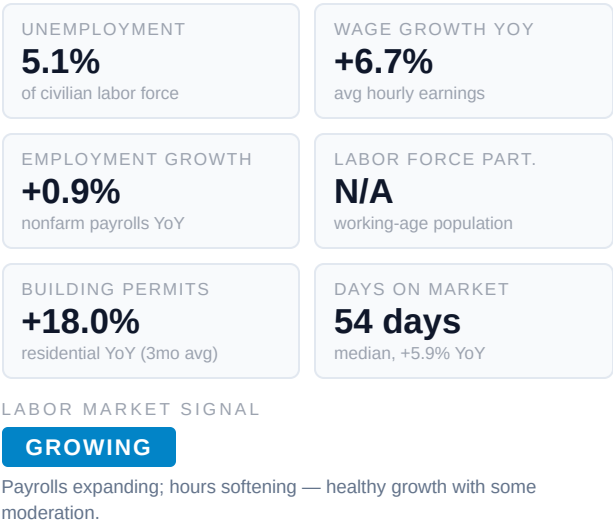
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
44.5th percentile
Rank 32 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Riverside earns a grade of C due to its severe labor market weakness, with an unemployment rate of 5.10% posing a significant consumer spending risk. The city's labor market is marked by below-average nonfarm employment growth of 0.88% year-over-year, indicating economic deceleration. Hourly earnings are rising 6.68% year-over-year, indicating a tight labor market that poses a real cost pressure for employers.

The city's cost of living composite score is 3.14, which is below average, and the office and professional worker share is notably low, ranking in the 2nd percentile. This poses a significant constraint for knowledge-economy businesses. The housing market presents a nuanced picture, with days on market increasing by 5.9% year-over-year to 54 days, indicating a slowing market.

Riverside's housing supply is keeping pace with demand, with building permits growing at an above-average rate of 18.04% year-over-year. The primary risk for businesses is the city's severe labor market weakness, which impacts consumer spending and demand. This makes it essential to carefully consider the potential risks and opportunities before making a location decision, as the city's labor market challenges and cost pressures must be weighed against its growing housing supply.

Sacramento

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
44.1th percentile
Rank 33 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		84
25% weight		
Unemployment		14
20% weight		
Wage Growth		30
15% weight		
Cost of Living		18
12% weight		
Labor Force Part.		67
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		28
10% weight		
Housing Access		64
5% weight		
Office Economy		30
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 4.8% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +3.0% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +1.0% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE PART. N/A working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS -15.5% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 39 days median, +8.3% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Sacramento earns an overall grade of B- and ranks in the 44th percentile out of 50 US metros, with its high unemployment rate of 4.80% indicating severe labor market weakness. The city's nonfarm employment growth rate is +1.00% YoY, a top-tier performance. The cost of living composite score is 4.27, ranking in the 18th percentile, making Sacramento one of the most expensive metros.

The interplay between strong employment growth and sharply declining building permits (-15.51% YoY) creates a key tension in the market. This decline leads to a housing supply squeeze, exacerbating affordability issues and potentially deterring workforce attraction. The days on market have increased by 8.3% YoY, with an average of 39 days, indicating a moderating housing market.

Sacramento offers a rapidly expanding job market, but with significant caveats, including an extremely high cost of living and potential housing supply squeeze. The city's labor market weakness is evident in its high unemployment rate of 4.80%. These factors compromise affordability and workforce attraction, ultimately affecting the viability of business operations in the area.

San Antonio

San Antonio-New Braunfels

C+

POOR

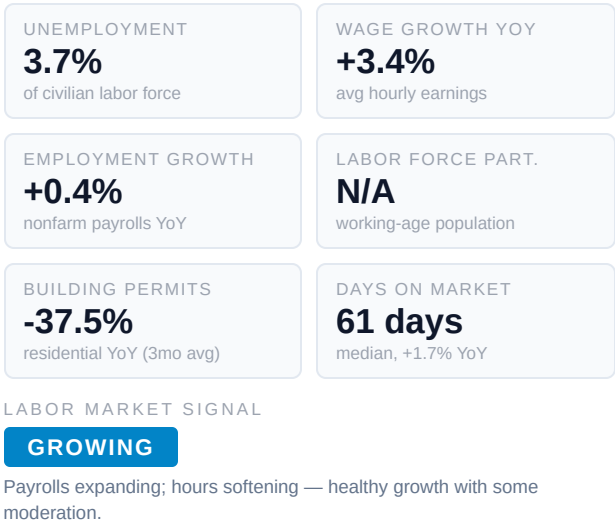
43.9th percentile

Rank 34 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

San Antonio earns a C+ overall grade, with its highly affordable environment being the single most important takeaway about this city. The city's cost of living composite score of 1.11 places it in the top tier, indicating a highly affordable environment. Labor force growth is above-average at 1.47% YoY, which is a positive workforce supply signal.

The housing market is contracting, with building permits declining sharply by 37.55% YoY, a bottom-tier performance. Days on market are increasing by 1.7% YoY, with an average of 61 days, signaling a slowing market. This scenario indicates demand erosion, particularly given the weak employment growth of 0.43% YoY. The city's professional talent pool ranks in the 26th percentile, posing constraints for specialized or senior roles.

San Antonio offers businesses a highly affordable cost environment and a growing labor force, but the primary risk lies in the city's sluggish employment growth and contracting housing supply. Decision-makers should be cautious of the potential for workforce attraction difficulties, which may offset the city's initial cost advantages. The city's affordability advantage is significant, but it is tempered by the fast-moving housing market and declining permits.

Tampa

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater

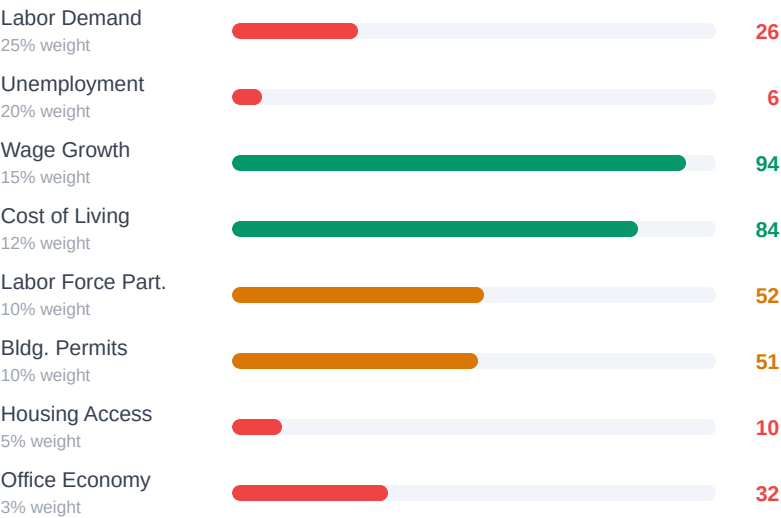
C+

POOR

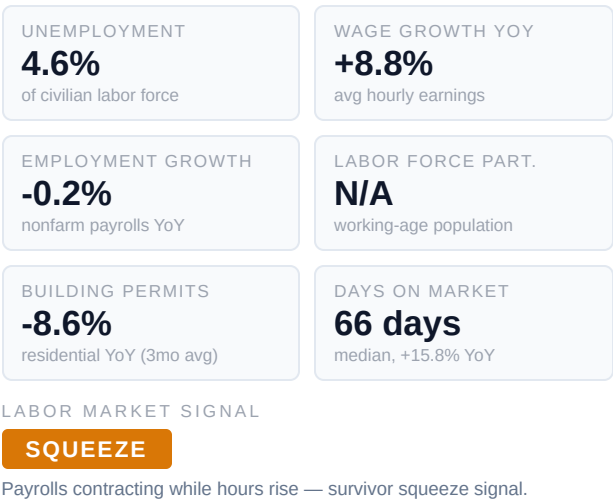
43.6th percentile

Rank 35 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Tampa earns a C+ grade, with its high unemployment rate of 4.60% being the most critical concern. This reflects a labor market characterized by severe weakness and potential consumer spending risk. The area's nonfarm employment growth is below average, with a -0.22% year-over-year change, indicating economic deceleration.

The cost of living composite ranks in the 84th percentile, making Tampa one of the most affordable metros. However, the housing market tells a different story, with days on market increasing by 15.8% year-over-year and homes taking an average of 66 days to sell, indicating a slowing market. This slowdown, combined with a below-average office and professional worker share, ranking in the 32th percentile, poses constraints for specialized or senior roles.

Tampa offers strong wage growth, with an 8.81% year-over-year increase, but decision-makers should weigh the benefits of affordability against the challenges of a slowing economy and constrained professional talent pool. The labor market's weakness and potential demand erosion in the housing market are primary risks that require careful consideration.

Oklahoma City

Oklahoma City

C+

POOR

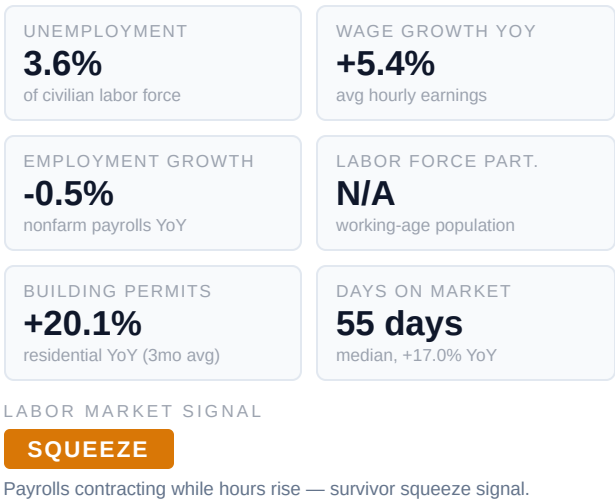
43.6th percentile

Rank 36 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Oklahoma City earns a grade of C+ due to its struggling labor market, with a nonfarm employment growth rate of -0.54% year-over-year. The city's labor force growth rate is only 0.23% year-over-year, indicating a slow expansion of the workforce. This contraction in jobs is a significant concern for businesses considering the city as a potential location.

The city's cost of living composite score of 1.13 places it among the most affordable metros, with a 90th percentile ranking. However, the low office and professional worker share, ranked in the 16th percentile, poses a significant constraint for knowledge-economy businesses. The housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by 17.0% year-over-year to 55 days, despite aggressive expansion in housing supply, with building permits up 20.14% year-over-year.

Oklahoma City offers an extremely affordable cost of living and a growing housing supply, but the primary risk is the city's struggling labor market. The weak job growth and low professional worker concentration make it a challenging location for businesses reliant on a skilled workforce. Decision-makers should carefully weigh these factors when considering Oklahoma City as a potential location, taking into account the city's unique combination of affordability and labor market challenges.

Indianapolis

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood

C+

POOR

42.4th percentile

Rank 37 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		20
25% weight		
Unemployment		96
20% weight		
Wage Growth		46
15% weight		
Cost of Living		6
12% weight		
Labor Force Part.		19
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		45
10% weight		
Housing Access		72
5% weight		
Office Economy		22
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 2.5% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +4.0% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH -0.7% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE PART. N/A working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS -10.3% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 51 days median, +15.9% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL WEAK Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Indianapolis earns a C+ overall grade, with its exceptionally low unemployment rate of 2.50% being the most important takeaway about this city. The city's labor market is tight, with businesses facing significant hiring competition due to a genuinely shallow pool of available workers, as the civilian labor force has shrunk by 0.36% year-over-year.

The city's cost of living composite score of 5.25 makes it one of the most expensive metros, constraining talent acquisition and consumer spending power. Nonfarm employment has declined by 0.66% year-over-year, and the professional talent pool ranks in the 22nd percentile, indicating below-average job growth and a thinner talent pool.

The housing market is slowing down, with days on market increasing by 15.9% year-over-year to an average of 51 days. This slowdown, combined with weak employment growth, may indicate demand erosion rather than a healthy normalization. The primary risk for businesses locating in Indianapolis is the potential for demand erosion, driven by weak job growth and a shrinking labor force, which undermines the city's economic momentum and limits opportunities for expansion.

Grand Rapids

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood

C+

POOR

41.9th percentile

Rank 38 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.0%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+3.9%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.4%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

N/A

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+55.2%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

44 days

median, +15.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood earns a C+ overall grade, with its shrinking labor force posing a substantial challenge for businesses. The city's civilian labor force is shrinking at a rate of -4.96% year-over-year, a bottom-tier performance, and nonfarm employment growth is -0.43% year-over-year, below average. The unemployment rate is 4.00%, but this does not offset the labor market's overall constraint.

The housing market is expanding, with building permits surging 55.17% year-over-year, a top-tier performance. However, homes are taking longer to sell, with days on market increasing by 15.8% year-over-year to an average of 44 days. The city's cost of living is high, ranking in the bottom tier with a score of 5.10, and the concentration of office and professional workers is low, ranking in the 8th percentile.

The city's labor market and high cost of living make it a difficult location for businesses to attract and retain talent. The shrinking labor force and limited professional workforce are primary risks for businesses considering this location, outweighing the benefits of an expanding housing supply. With a labor force shrinking at a rate of -4.96% year-over-year, businesses must carefully weigh these challenges when evaluating Grand Rapids as a potential location.

St. Louis

St. Louis

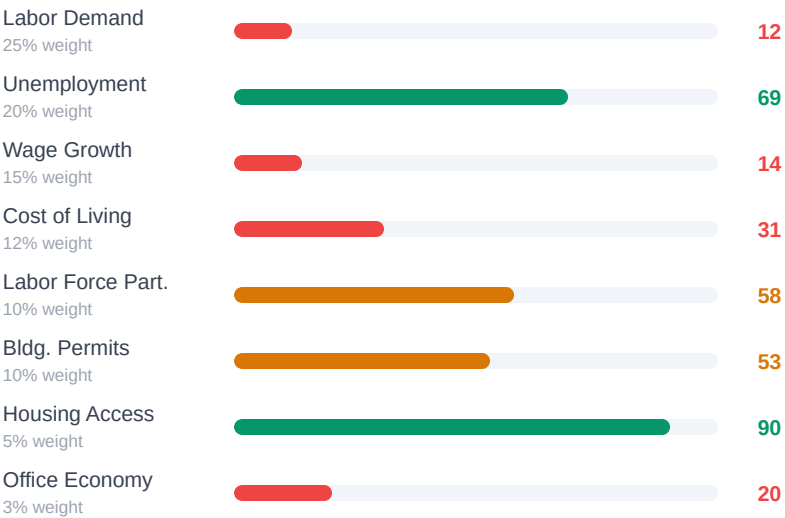
C+

POOR

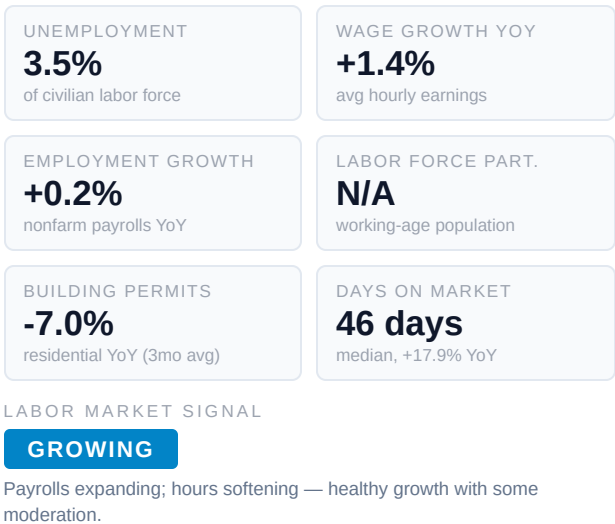
38.9th percentile

Rank 39 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

St. Louis earns a C+ grade, with its slow job growth and stagnant wages posing significant risks for businesses. The city's labor market is characterized by near-stagnant job growth, with nonfarm employment increasing by only 0.17% year-over-year, and wage growth of 1.41%, both of which are bottom-tier metrics. The unemployment rate is 3.50%, but this positive indicator is overshadowed by the lackluster job and wage growth.

The housing market in St. Louis is slowing down, with homes taking 46 days to sell on average, and a significant increase of 17.9% year-over-year in days on market. This slowdown, combined with weak employment growth and stagnant wage growth, indicates demand erosion. The cost of living in St. Louis is below average, with a score of 3.30, but the thin professional talent pool, ranking in the 20th percentile, poses constraints for businesses seeking specialized or senior roles.

St. Louis offers an affordable cost of living, but its slow job growth, stagnant wages, and slowing housing market pose significant risks. The city's limited access to specialized talent, with a talent pool ranking in the 20th percentile, could hinder long-term growth and success. With nonfarm employment growth at 0.17% and wage growth at 1.41%, businesses considering locating in St. Louis must carefully weigh these factors against the city's low cost of living score of 3.30.

Virginia Beach

Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk

C+

POOR

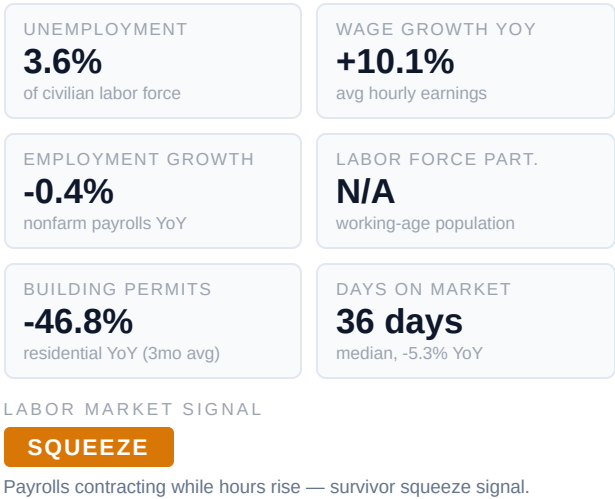
38.3th percentile

Rank 40 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Virginia Beach earns a C+ grade, with its shrinking civilian labor force posing a significant structural headwind for businesses. The area's civilian labor force has declined by 2.41% year-over-year, and total nonfarm employment growth is stagnant, with a -0.41% year-over-year change. Wages are rising rapidly, with a 10.08% year-over-year increase, indicating a strong labor market for existing workers.

The housing market is experiencing a supply squeeze, with building permits declining sharply by 46.79% year-over-year. Homes are selling in fewer days than last year, averaging just 36 days on market, creating a competitive environment for new hires. This contraction, combined with rapid wage growth, raises questions about the underlying health of the labor market, potentially indicating a mix shift toward higher-paying jobs.

The primary risk for businesses locating in this area is the potential difficulty in attracting and retaining talent due to the limited housing supply and rapidly rising home prices. Despite the affordability advantage of a below-average cost of living, the competitive housing market and shrinking labor force pose significant challenges for businesses seeking to expand their workforce in Virginia Beach.

Minneapolis

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington

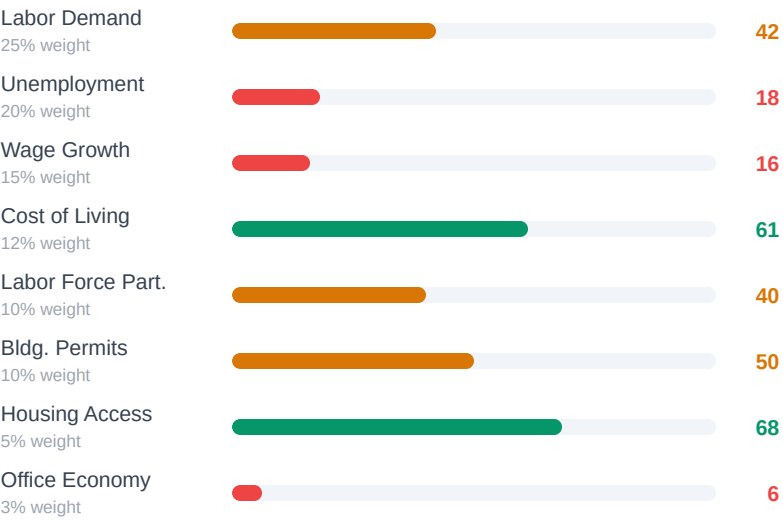
C

VERY POOR

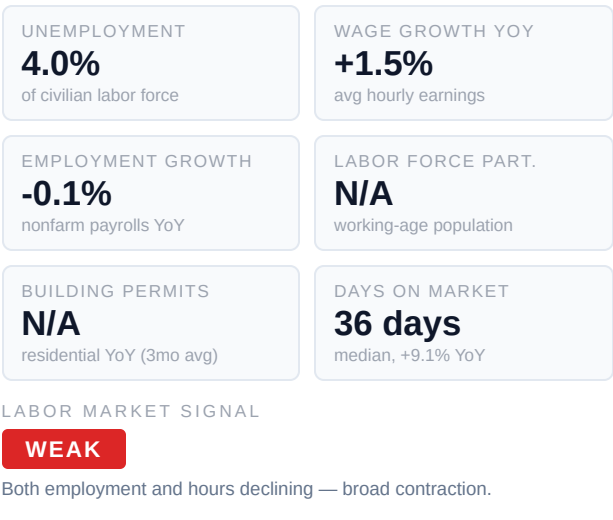
36.5th percentile

Rank 41 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington earns a C grade, with its severe labor market weakness being the most critical issue. The 4.00% unemployment rate, ranking in the 18th percentile, signals this weakness, and stagnant wage growth, with hourly earnings increasing by only 1.47% year-over-year, placing it in the 16th percentile, compounds the problem. The low office and professional worker share, ranking in the 6th percentile, further constrains the city's economic potential.

The cost of living composite scores 2.01, ranking in the 61st percentile, indicating a below-average cost of living. The housing market is slowing, with homes taking 36 days to sell on average, and a 9.1% year-over-year increase in days on market. This slowing demand is concerning, given the weak labor market and stagnant wage growth.

The city's labor market challenges make it a less attractive location for businesses reliant on a skilled and growing workforce. The low professional worker concentration and high unemployment rate raise questions about the city's ability to support knowledge-economy businesses. With a below-average cost of living being the sole advantage, the primary risk for businesses in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is the labor market's structural weaknesses, which will constrain hiring capacity and consumer spending.

Milwaukee

Milwaukee-Waukesha

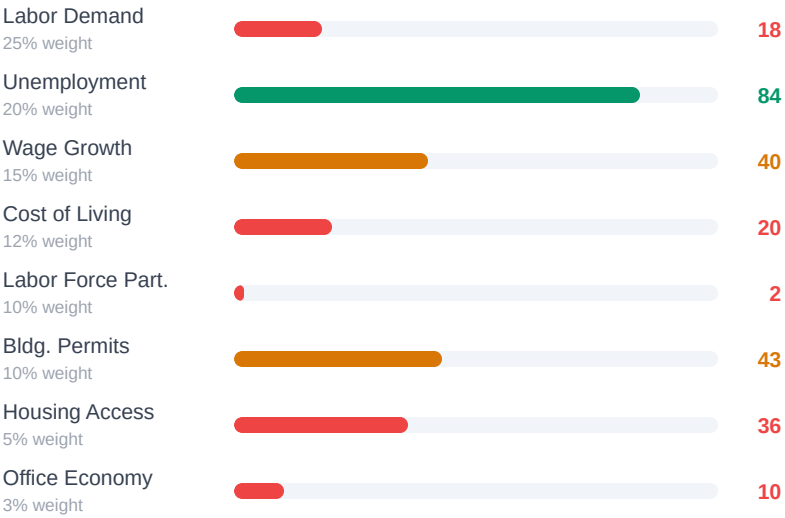
C

VERY POOR

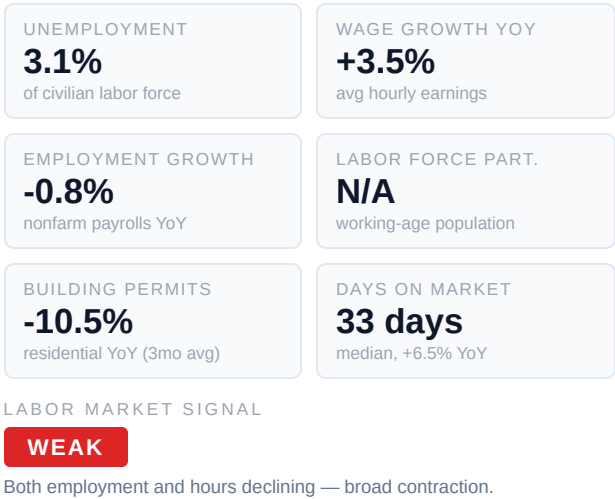
36.2th percentile

Rank 42 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Milwaukee earns a B+ grade, with its exceptionally low unemployment rate of 3.10% being the most important takeaway about this city. The city's labor market is highly competitive, with a tight hiring environment. However, this is paired with a shrinking civilian labor force, which has contracted by 3.11% year-over-year, posing a structural headwind for businesses seeking to expand their workforce.

The city's nonfarm employment growth has stagnated, with a year-over-year decline of 0.75%, indicating a broader economic slowdown. Milwaukee's low office and professional worker concentration, ranking in the 10th percentile, poses a significant constraint for knowledge-economy businesses. The city's housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by 6.5% year-over-year, and homes selling at an average of 33 days.

Milwaukee offers a highly competitive labor market, but with significant constraints, including a shrinking labor force and limited professional talent pool. The primary risk for businesses is demand erosion, driven by weak employment growth and a slowing housing market, which limits the city's attractiveness as a location for expansion or relocation.

Chicago

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin

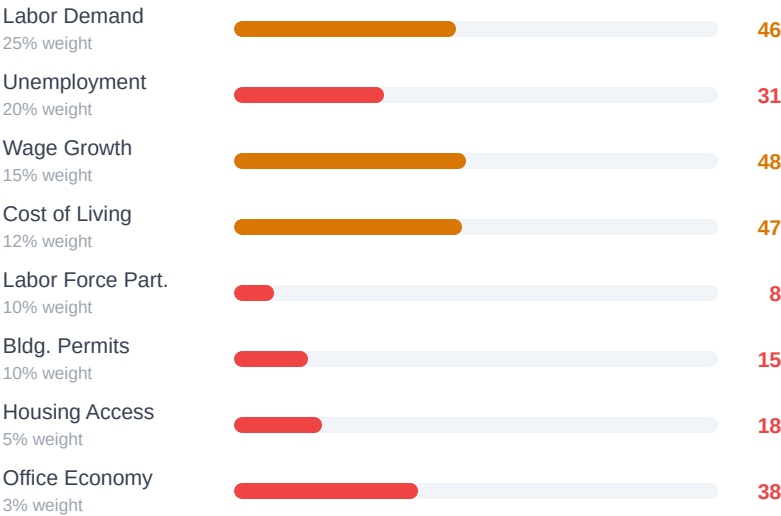
C

VERY POOR

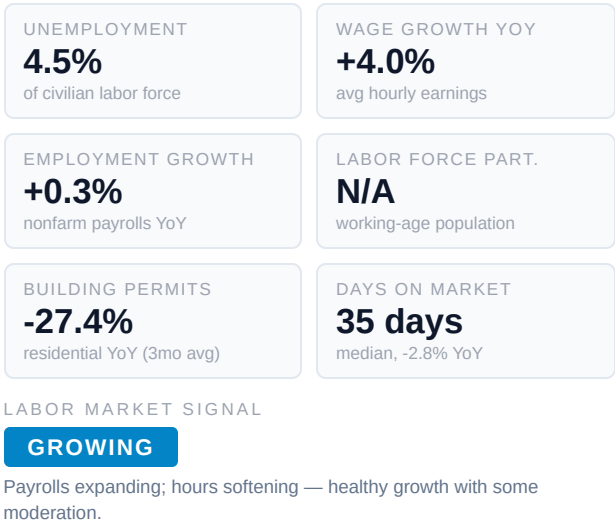
34.8th percentile

Rank 43 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Chicago earns a grade of C, ranking 34.8th percentile out of 50 US metros, with its struggling labor market and constrained housing supply being the most significant concerns. The city's unemployment rate of 4.50% signals labor market slack, while the civilian labor force is shrinking at a rate of -1.72% YoY, posing a significant structural headwind for businesses seeking to expand headcount. The sharp decline in building permits, down 27.41% YoY, indicates a contracting housing supply.

The housing market is highly competitive, with homes selling in just 35 days on average, a pace that is accelerating, with a -2.8% YoY change. This fast-moving market is driven by supply constraints, as evidenced by the decline in building permits. The thinner professional talent pool, ranking in the 38th percentile, poses constraints for specialized or senior roles, adding to the city's labor market challenges.

Chicago's labor market has some slack, potentially easing hiring, but its constrained housing supply and shrinking labor force pose significant risks. The city's tightening housing market and labor market headwinds drive the potential for affordability stress and workforce attraction difficulties, making this a primary concern for businesses considering location in Chicago.

Detroit

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn

C

VERY POOR

32.9th percentile

Rank 44 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Detroit earns a low grade due to its severe labor market weakness, with an unemployment rate and stagnant wage growth of +1.58% YoY both ranking in the bottom tier. Nonfarm employment is declining by -0.16% YoY, indicating economic deceleration. The labor force is growing slowly, at +0.59% YoY, which constrains hiring capacity.

The housing market is slowing down, with building permits declining by -10.94% YoY, indicating a tightening of housing supply. Homes take an average of 45 days to sell, with days on market increasing by +7.1% YoY. This slowdown, combined with weak employment growth and declining permits, poses a risk to consumer spending.

Detroit's business environment is marked by significant labor market challenges and a slowing housing market. The primary risk for businesses is weak consumer spending and demand erosion, driven by high unemployment and stagnant wages, making it a less attractive location for investment.

Jacksonville

Jacksonville

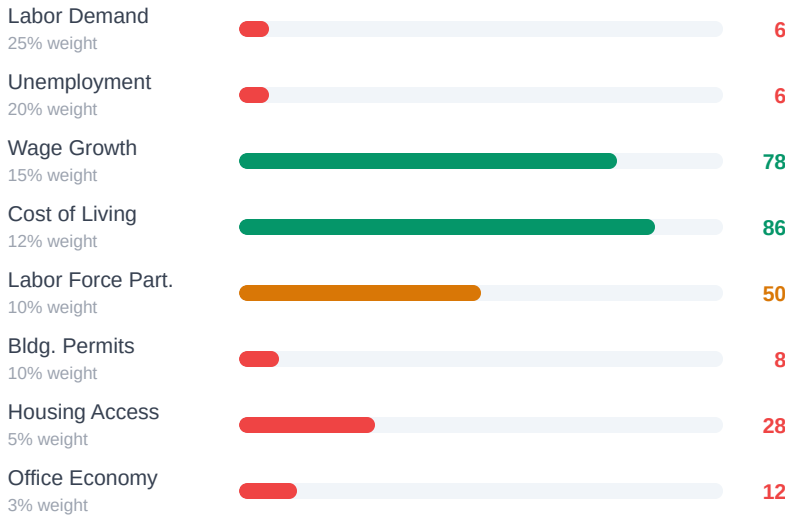
C

VERY POOR

32.3th percentile

Rank 45 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.6%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+6.4%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.5%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

N/A
working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-32.7%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

58 days
median, +1.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Jacksonville earns a grade of C due to its severe labor market weakness, with an unemployment rate of 4.60% and nonfarm employment growth of -0.49% year-over-year. The city's low professional and office worker concentration, ranking in the 12th percentile, poses a significant constraint for knowledge-economy businesses. Jacksonville boasts a strong cost advantage, with a cost of living composite score of 1.30, making it one of the most affordable metros in the dataset.

Wage growth is solid at +6.38% year-over-year, but this is likely due to a mix shift towards higher-paying survivors rather than broad labor market health. The housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by 1.8% year-over-year to an average of 58 days, and building permits declining sharply by -32.70% year-over-year. This slowdown in the housing market, combined with the city's affordability advantage, indicates that demand for housing is softening.

Jacksonville's cost advantage is a significant benefit for businesses, but the city's struggling labor market poses a primary risk, hindering workforce attraction and retention. The city's economic weaknesses, including its high unemployment rate and low professional worker concentration, pose significant challenges for businesses looking to establish or expand operations in the area, with a nonfarm employment growth of -0.49% year-over-year.

Richmond

Richmond

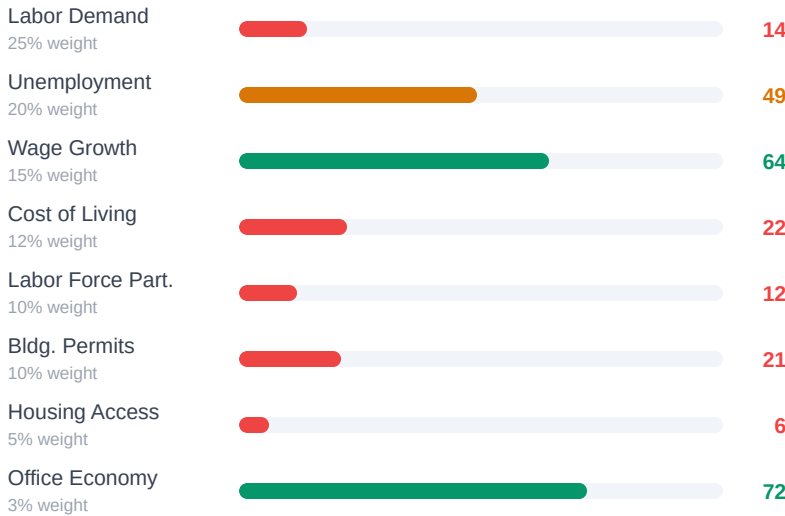
C-

CRITICAL

31.4th percentile

Rank 46 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.3%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+5.4%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.4%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

N/A

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-20.3%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

39 days

median, -11.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Richmond earns a C- grade, with its shrinking labor force and slow employment growth posing significant risks for businesses. The city's labor force is contracting at a rate of -1.22% year-over-year, and nonfarm employment growth is -0.36% year-over-year, placing it in the bottom tier. Solid wage growth of 5.36% year-over-year is a positive note, but it also exerts cost pressure on businesses.

The city's housing market is heating up, with homes selling in an average of 39 days, driven by a supply contraction due to a -20.27% year-over-year decline in building permits. Richmond's above-average cost of living, with a composite score of 3.79, necessitates wage premiums to attract talent, which could be exacerbated by the rapid housing market.

Richmond's challenging labor market environment and rapidly moving housing market make it essential for businesses to carefully consider these factors when making location decisions. The city's labor market risks and affordability concerns must be weighed against its solid wage growth, highlighting the need for a nuanced approach to expansion decisions in Richmond.

Baltimore

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson

C-

CRITICAL

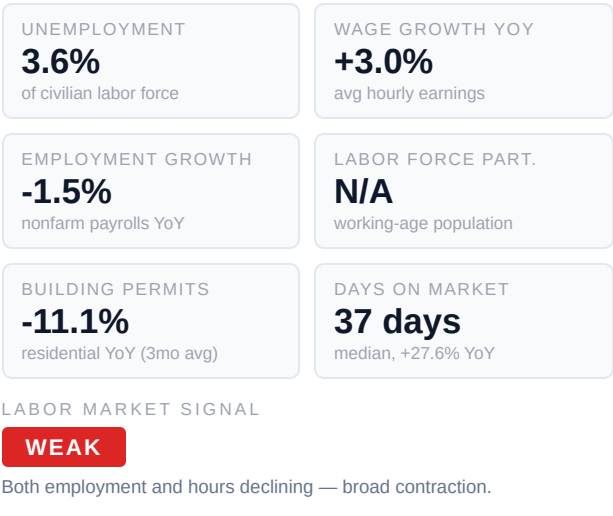
30.6th percentile

Rank 47 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Baltimore earns a bottom-tier grade due to its significant structural headwinds, with nonfarm employment growth contracting by -1.46% YoY and a shrinking civilian labor force, down 0.62% YoY. The city's unemployment rate is 3.60%, elevated compared to its peers, indicating labor market slack. This combination of factors defines Baltimore as a market with weakened local consumer demand and limited opportunities for business growth.

The housing market is slowing, with homes taking 37 days to sell on average, but with a significant increase of 27.6% YoY, and declining building permits, down 11.14% YoY, indicating demand erosion. The cost of living is above average at a score of 1.86, but this is not enough to offset the labor market challenges. The professional talent pool ranks in the 24th percentile, posing constraints for specialized or senior roles.

Baltimore's struggling labor market, characterized by job losses and a shrinking workforce, poses significant challenges for businesses seeking to grow and expand in the city. The city's cost advantage due to its low cost of living is not enough to offset these challenges, making it a less attractive location for investment and development. With a thinner professional talent pool and weakened local consumer demand, businesses may find it difficult to thrive in this market.

Orlando

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford

C-

CRITICAL

29.6th percentile

Rank 48 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		64
Unemployment 20% weight		10
Wage Growth 15% weight		12
Cost of Living 12% weight		41
Labor Force Part. 10% weight		23
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		6
Housing Access 5% weight		12
Office Economy 3% weight		44

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 4.4% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +1.4% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.5% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE PART. N/A working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS -35.6% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 67 days median, +11.7% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Orlando earns a C- overall grade, with its struggling labor market being the most significant concern. The city's 4.40% unemployment rate, ranking in the bottom tier, signals severe labor market weakness, posing a significant risk to consumer spending. Stagnant wage growth of +1.36% YoY, also in the bottom tier, means workers have limited leverage, which could further soften the market.

The housing market is experiencing demand erosion, with building permits declining sharply by -35.64% YoY, a bottom-tier performance. Days on market are increasing by +11.7% YoY to an average of 67 days, indicating a slowing market. This scenario is driven by weak employment growth and declining permits, flagging a risk of decreased affordability and relocation challenges for new hires.

Orlando's labor market and housing supply challenges pose significant risks for businesses, including decreased consumer spending power and affordability issues. Stagnant wages, high unemployment, and a contracting housing supply drive these concerns. Despite some positive employment growth, such as above-average nonfarm employment growth of +0.46% YoY, the city's overall economic landscape remains a concern for businesses considering Orlando.

Washington DC

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria

C-

CRITICAL

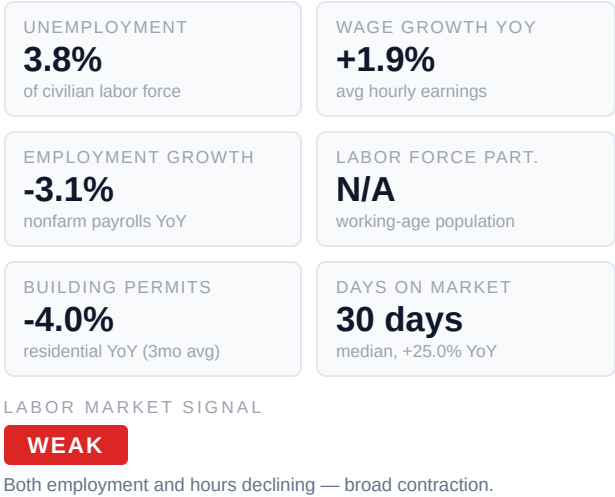
26.4th percentile

Rank 49 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Washington D.C. earns a C- grade, with its struggling labor market being the most important takeaway. The city's nonfarm employment growth is -3.09% YoY and its civilian labor force is down 1.82% YoY, indicating a contraction. This is further exacerbated by an elevated unemployment rate of 3.80%, signaling labor market slack and weakened local consumer demand.

The housing market is slowing, with homes taking 30 days to sell on average, a 25.0% YoY increase. This rise in days on market, combined with weak employment growth and falling building permits, indicates demand erosion. The city ranks in the 34th percentile for office and professional worker share, posing constraints for businesses seeking specialized or senior roles.

Washington D.C.'s labor market offers potential for easier hiring due to slack, but the primary risk is the city's weakening economic fundamentals. Businesses must weigh the benefits of a potentially lower-cost labor environment against the risks of a slowing economy and shrinking talent pool. The city's economic challenges make it essential for businesses to carefully consider these factors when deciding on a location.

Portland

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro

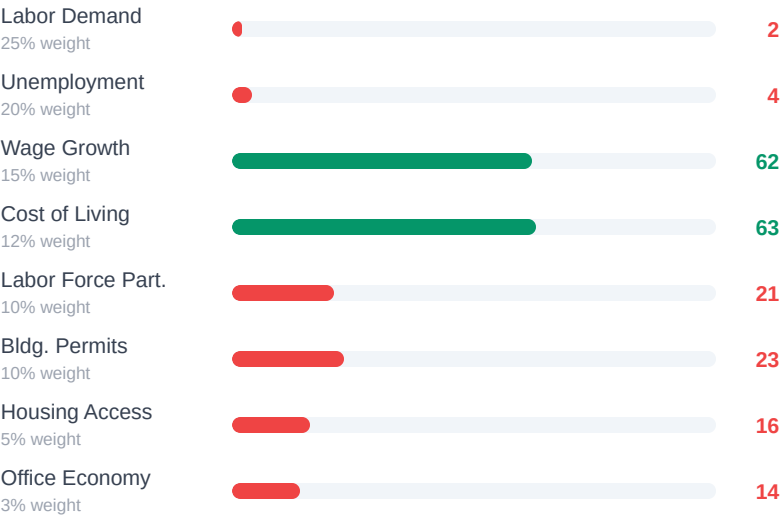
D

EMERGENCY

23.9th percentile

Rank 50 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.9%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+5.0%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-1.8%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

N/A

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-18.1%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

49 days

median, -3.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Portland earns a grade of D, or 23.9th percentile out of 50 US metros, due to its struggling labor market. The city's unemployment rate is 4.90% and nonfarm employment growth is -1.84% year-over-year, indicating a contraction. The labor force is growing at just 0.04% year-over-year, further compounding the weakness.

The city boasts solid wage growth of 4.98% year-over-year, which supports consumer spending. However, the housing market tells a different story, with homes selling quickly at an average of 49 days on market and a year-over-year decrease of 3.9%. Building permits are down 18.14% year-over-year, indicating a thinning housing supply.

Portland offers a cost advantage, with a cost of living composite score indicating above-average affordability. The city's low concentration of professional and office workers, ranking in the 14th percentile, poses a significant constraint for knowledge-economy businesses. The primary risk for businesses is the city's labor market weakness, which limits hiring capacity and talent attraction, making Portland a challenging location for businesses to thrive.